

On Passives and *U*-syncretism: A Response to Key 2024

Chigchi Bai

Inner Mongolia University of Finance and Economics

chigchi.bai@imufe.edu.cn

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Abstract

While Key (2024) is right in claiming that *u*-syncretism is a surface phenomenon that can “mask” the structural difference between canonical and noncanonical passive derivations, he incorrectly analyzes *u*-syncretic passive morphology as a manifestation of a nonactive Voice head. This paper proposes an alternative approach based on the following specific points. First, agents are suppressed in noncanonical (low) passives but not in canonical passives; an internal argument is promoted to the low Voice layer in noncanonical passives and a higher Voice layer in canonical passives. Second, *u*-syncretism arises from internal argument promotion to the low Voice layer, rather than being a manifestation of a nonactive Voice head. Third, as a syntactic head, Voice is not specified for an active-nonactive alternation; instead, it consistently introduces a syntactic argument through either external or internal merge; instead of an alternating Voice head (active/nonactive), Free Merge provides the basis for both passive variation and *u*-syncretism.

Keywords: Passive; *u*-syncretism; agent; internal argument promotion; Voice

1. Introduction: Key (2024) and an alternative

1.1. Key (2024)

Key (2024) notes that Turkish passive morphemes can be attached to a transitive verb stem or a non-transitive stem, which is an intransitive verb root or a non-verbal root. In the former case, a canonical passive is formed (1a), while in the latter, an anticausative is formed (1b).¹ Anticausatives are “noncanonical passives” in the sense that they do not express a regular, rigid passive meaning while containing passive morphology.²

(1) Passive formation in Turkish

a. $V_{tr} + PASS \rightarrow$ canonical passive

b. $V_{intr} + PASS \rightarrow$ anticausative (noncanonical passive)

Importantly, canonical passives derived from overtly marked transitive verbs such as *öl-dür-ül* ‘be killed’ do not exhibit *u*-syncretism with anticausatives in a strict sense, despite sharing the same passive morphology, since they do not have the unaccusative nature found in anticausatives. In contrast, passives derived from unmarked transitive verbs such as *aç-ıl* display *u*-syncretism since they can have the unaccusative nature. That is, *aç-ıl* means either “be opened (by someone)”, where *aç* is a bare transitive stem, or “open (by itself)”, where *aç* is an intransitive stem.

(2) a. Non-syncretic:

$V_{dir/eD} + PASS \rightarrow$ canonical passive (e.g., *öl-dür-ül* ‘be killed’)

b. Syncretic:

$V-\emptyset + PASS \rightarrow$ canonical passive (e.g., *aç-ıl* ‘be opened (by someone)’)

noncanonical passive (anticausative) (e.g., *aç-ıl* ‘open (by itself)’)

¹ A reflexive reading is also available with passive morphology, leading to three-way syncretism, in Turkish and other languages. However, unlike anticausatives, (verbal) reflexives do not have dedicated voice morphology. The syncretic nature of reflexives is an epiphenomenon. This paper thus do not discuss reflexives, focusing on passive-anticausative syncretism.

² “Noncanonical passive” roughly corresponds to Key’s (2024: 346) term “detransitivizing passive”.

The canonical-noncanonical distinction of passives thus lies in whether they are derived from overtly marked transitive stems and the syncretic nature of the noncanonical type relies on the absence of transitive marking, as summarized below.

(3) Canonical vs. Noncanonical/syncretic passives (Key 2024)

	Canonical passive	Noncanonical passive
Morphology	<i>-Il, -In, -n</i>	<i>-Il, -In, -n</i>
<i>U</i> -syncretism	non-syncretic	syncretic
Interpretation	rigidly passive	anticausative
Unaccusative nature	unavailable	available
Stem type	transitive-marked	non-transitive-marked

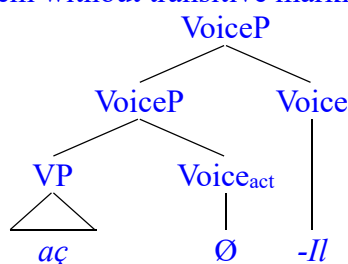
The key takeaway from Key's (2024) proposal is thus that *u*-syncretism reflects morphosyntactic ambiguity at least in Turkish but is not simply the manifestation of a single middle Voice structure with multiple interpretations as claimed by Embick (2004).

Adopting the alternating-Voice framework established by Schäfer (2008), Bruening (2013), Alexiadou (2014), and Alexiadou et al. (2015), Key (2024) analyzes the structural differentiation between canonical and noncanonical passives and the *u*-syncretic nature of the noncanonical type. His analysis centers on the following core proposals.

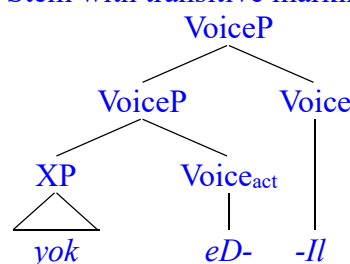
A canonical passive interpretation is obtained where a nonactive Voice layer is projected on top of an active Voice layer (4). A noncanonical passive (anticausative) interpretation is obtained where a single nonactive Voice layer is projected directly above VP (5).³ Syncretism arises with verbs (e.g., *aç-il*) that have both the stacked Voice structure with null transitive marking (4a) and the single Voice structure (5a).

(4) (Canonical) passive structure in Key (2024)

a. Stem without transitive marking⁴

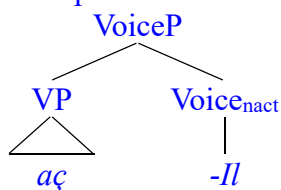


b. Stem with transitive marking

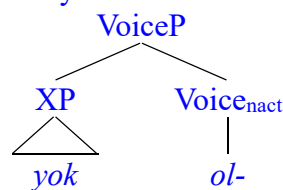


(5) (Noncanonical) passive and anticausative structures in Key (2024)

a. With syncretic passive suffix



b. With non-syncretic suffix



Key (2024: 367) suggests that Voice_{act} has a D feature in (4), which leads to overt transitive morphology (such as the suffix *-Dİr* as well as its allomorphic variants and the active light verb *eD-* in Turkish). In contrast, when lacking D, Voice is spelled out as passive/nonactive morphology (such as *-Il* as well as its allomorphs and the nonactive light verb *ol-*), as in (4) and (5). Key (2024) formulates this as follows.

(6) a. Voice → Voice[NACT] (*-Il* etc.)

b. Voice{D} → Voice[CAUSE] (*-Dİr* etc.) (Key 2024: 367)

³ Although a higher Voice head is left as an underspecified head, as in (4), it is in fact treated like a nonactive Voice in Key (2024).

⁴ The higher Voice here corresponds to Bruening's (2013) Pass(ive) head on top of VoiceP (Key 2024: 365). The lower Voice can either bundle with the light verb *v* or be split from it in Turkish (Key 2024: 335ff).

It then follows that for Key (2024), the canonical-noncanonical distinction of the passive is reduced to the presence/absence of a D feature and transitive marking. Key’s (2024) D feature, identical to Bruening’s (2013) N feature, does not entail an actual DP argument, yet it represents external argument semantics.

Notably, postulating a non-argument-introducing Voice head for passives (Bruening 2013; Alexiadou 2014; Alexiadou et al. 2015) takes its rise from the wrong assumption in (7).⁵

(7) *Passives lack a syntactic external argument.*

This wrong assumption leads to the correlation of *u*-syncretism to the purported active-nonactive alternation of Voice, on the one hand, and the failure to correctly capture the structural distinction and similarity between canonical and noncanonical passives as characterized in (8), on the other hand.

(8) a. *Canonical passive: Passive with a syntactic external argument*

b. *Noncanonical passive: Passive without a syntactic external argument*

Under the alternating-Voice approach to passives (such as Key 2024 and others), what shapes a passive in the syntax is so-called nonactive Voice rather than internal argument promotion. This leads to the wrong result that internal argument promotion is disassociated from passive morphology and passive semantics of both canonical and noncanonical passives, violating the Mirror Principle (Baker 1985).

1.2. An alternative

This paper shows that Key’s (2024) analysis sketched in (4) through (6), along with the misleading assumption in (7), fails to accurately account for passive derivation and *u*-syncretism. The labels “Voice[–D]” and “Voice[+D]” are adopted here to consistently refer to Voice heads that do not, and do, introduce a syntactic argument, respectively. Voice heads in (4) through (6) are thus Voice[–D], not Voice[+D], since they do not introduce a syntactic argument, despite the D feature on Voice_{act}.

The postulation of Voice[–D] in various forms has been based on the researchers’ presupposition that in passives, the voice proper, agents are absent from the syntax (Pylkkänen 2008; Schäfer 2008, 2015; Bruening 2013; Legate 2014; Alexiadou et al. 2015; Legate et al. 2020). However, there is solid evidence that agents are not suppressed but rather syntactically projected in canonical passives. So-called agent-suppression in canonical passives is illusive. This paper (Section 2) demonstrates that what is suppressed in canonical passives is in fact INITIATOR rather than an agent. The idea behind this is that an agent is composed of two primitive roles, namely, INITIATOR and DOER, and that they can be bundled or split (Lundin 2003; Sigurðsson and Wood 2021). In this paper, as opposed to (6), (9) is proposed, where *Voice is always Voice[+D]* and can be recursive (notated as Voice1 and Voice2). I will show that canonical passives are “Voice2-over-Voice1-over-V” and noncanonical passives are “Voice1-over-V”.

- (9) a. [VoiceP₁ DP_{2j} [VP DP_{1i}]] — Transitive
 b. [VoiceP₂ DP_{1i} [VoiceP₁ DP_{2j} [VP *t_i*]]] — Canonical passive
 c. [VoiceP₁ DP_{1i} [VP *t_i*]] — Noncanonical passive

The transitive-passive distinction is thus not attributed to dedicated active-nonactive alternation of Voice but to the type of Merge as a syntactic operation applied in introducing DPs through a Voice head. If external merge (EM) applies, then a new DP (DP₂) is introduced by Voice₁, yielding a transitive structure (9a) and if, subsequently, internal merge (IM) applies, then the old DP (DP₁) is promoted to a higher Voice layer (VoiceP₂), yielding a canonical passive

⁵ Many researchers have attempted to validate various diagnostics as evidence for the absence of external arguments in passives. However, their diagnostics are not true evidence. Absence of evidence is not evidence of absence.

structure (9b). If IM applies in the lower Voice layer (VoiceP1), then DP1 is promoted to Spec of Voice1, yielding a noncanonical passive structure (9c). In (9c), the promoted internal argument DP1 wins the competition for Spec of VoiceP, precluding the introduction of an external argument DP2. Without an external argument in the syntax, VoiceP1 cannot be transitive but rather intransitive (anticausative, etc.). Internal argument promotion leads to the affixation of passive morphology for Voice1 and an associated passive reading, as a Mirror Principle effect. The passive reading here is not rigid, justifying the term “noncanonical”, due to the absence of an external argument in the syntax. In contrast, in (9b), the passive reading is rigid, justifying the term “canonical”, since the passive is derived from a transitive stem, where an external argument DP2 is syntactically present.

The distinction between canonical and noncanonical passives thus hinges on the presence or absence of an external argument in the syntax, alongside the varying heights of the internal argument’s landing site. For *u*-syncretism to occur, the landing site must be situated in VoiceP1, the lower Voice layer.

(10) a. *U*-syncretism arises from internal argument promotion to the low Voice layer.

b. $[\text{VoiceP1 DP1}_i [\text{VP } t_i]] \rightarrow u\text{-syncretism}$

In this sense, *u*-syncretism is low voice syncretism. This is why canonical passives do not exhibit *u*-syncretism. Transitive marking blocks true *u*-syncretism, as in Turkish (Key 2024) and Mongolian (Section 5), because when an external argument DP2 is introduced by Voice1 via EM, VoiceP1, serving as the stem of canonical passive, comes with the transitive rather than unaccusative nature, rendering the canonical passive fundamentally different from anticausatives.

1.3. Organization of the paper

Having overviewed Key’s (2024) proposal and an alternative, the following sections justify the latter. Section 2 illustrates the difference between canonical and low passives and shows that agents are suppressed in the latter but not in the former. Section 3 argues that agents are split into INITIATOR and DOER, the first of which is suppressed in short canonical passives (SCP) but not in long canonical passives (LCP). Section 4 presents an analysis in which Voice heads recursively occur in passives, yielding a Split VoiceP structure. Section 5 discusses how the analysis proposed in Section 4 explains the difference between noncanonical passives and pure anticausatives. Section 6 concludes this paper, suggesting that a Split VoiceP structure is universally available for voice constructions.

2. Agents are suppressed in low passives but not in canonical passives

Any approach to passive derivation and *u*-syncretism grounded on the assumption that the syntax provides specifierless Voice for passives would fail. This assumption is wrong since it was brought about by the researchers’ presupposition that agentive phrases are always suppressed in passives. While it is established that there are passives that suppress the agent, it is equally true that there are ones that do not. Therefore, in approaching passive-related phenomena, including *u*-syncretism, the distinction must first be made between agent-suppressing and agent-projecting passives.

Let us begin by noting the oblique phrase, whose status has been controversial among researchers. Some researchers take it as a syntactic argument while others take it as an adjunct. As has been noted by Collins (2005, 2024), Huang et al. (2009), Landau (2010), Müller (2019), and Sulemana (2022), there is plenty of cross-linguistic evidence that the oblique phrase is projected as a syntactic argument in canonical passives.⁶

⁶ “Oblique phrase” here refers to any phrase that is not a core argument of the sentence (like the subject or direct object). Dative phrases and PPs such as the *by*-phrase are thus all considered oblique phrases.

To begin with, the oblique phrase in passives can act as a binder of a reflexive pronoun and/or an anaphor, a controller of PRO, and a licenser of a depictive secondary predicate, cross-linguistically, indicating that it is a syntactic argument. The following set of English examples from Collins (2024) are a good illustration of this.

- (11) a. That book was written [by John]_i all by himself_i.
 b. The book was written [by John]_i [PRO_i to impress his wife].
 c. That book was written [by John]_i while PRO_i working at a bakery.
 d. Breakfast is usually eaten [by the campers]_i [PRO_i nude].

That external arguments are not suppressed in the syntax is also true in agglutinating languages such as Japanese and Mongolian. In (12), which is a Japanese passive (of-causative) sentence, the dative agent *Taroo* antecedes the anaphor *kare-zisin* ‘himself’, and in (13), which is a Mongolian passive, the dative agent *bagš* ‘teacher’ antecedes the anaphor *öör* ‘self’, indicating that they are syntactic arguments.

- (12) Hanako_j-ga Taroo_i-ni kare-zisin_i/*_j-no kuruma-kara ori-sase-rare-ta.
 Hanako-NOM Taro-DAT himself-GEN car-from get off-CS-PS-PST
 ‘Hanako was forced/caused to get out of his car (= Taro’s car).’

- (13) Surugč_j bagš-d_i (öör_i/*_j-in) ger-ees-ni höö-gd-sen.
 student-NOM teacher-DAT self-GEN house-ABL-PSS[3] drive out-PS-PST
 ‘The student was driven out by the teacher from his (own) house (= the teacher’s house).’

Agent-suppressing passives, in contrast, do not allow agentive phrases as syntactic arguments and are cross-linguistically attested in languages such as Greek, Turkish, and Mongolian. In what follows, let us focus on Mongolian, an understudied language.

In Mongolian, passive morphology can tolerate dative phrases, without entailing an agentive interpretation, in cases such as (14) and (15).

- (14) Nad-d hüč nem-gd-sen.
 1SG-DAT strength-NOM add-PS-PST
 ‘For me, strength increased.’
 ‘*Strength was added by me.’ (Bai 2023: 27)

- (15) Üüd salhin-d / *Baatar-d nee-gd-sen.
 door wind-DAT / John-DAT open-PS-PST
 ‘The door opened from the wind / *by Baatar.’ (Bai 2025b: 117)

In (14), the dative phrase is not an agent but rather a recipient or beneficiary. Note that the dative phrase cannot antecede an anaphor; nor does it allow a secondary predicates and control PRO, exemplification left out here. Additionally, the dative phrase occurs before the nominative phrase and is more topical than it. According to Passive Universal 3 in Haspelmath (2024), if active and passive constructions differ with respect to topicality of agent and patient, then the patient is more topical in the passive, or the agent is less topical, or both. This means that the sentence-initial dative phrase, not being less topical, in (14) is not an agent normally interpreted for canonical passives. In another case, as in (15), the dative phrase is tolerated only where it expresses natural force such as wind and rain, which is not an agent but rather a cause (not causer). However, (15), and (14) as well, feeds the Passive Voice Alternation in Haspelmath (2024): In a passive voice alternation, the uncoded alternant is transitive (with A- and P-arguments), and in the coded alternant, the basic A is downgraded, and the basic P corresponds to S. In (14) and (15), the basic P of the base verbs corresponds to a nominative subject phrase. This makes them passive-like constructions but different from canonical passives. While Haspelmath’s (2024) universals are not particularly about the argumental status of the oblique phrase, passives like (12–13) and those like (14–15) do differ in whether the oblique phrase is an agent or not.⁷ Note that the latter resemble dyadic anticausatives, where the oblique phrase

⁷ See Alexiadou et al. (2015), Key (2024), and others for cross-linguistic facts pointing to this passive

resembles an applied argument, which is not true of the former.

Passives thus must be distinguished between agent-projecting and agent-suppressing. For the former, the oblique phrase mirrors the interpretation of the external argument in the active (Collins 2024: 99), which is not true for the latter. That is, external arguments are projected in agent-projecting passives in the same way as in transitives, as argued by Collins (2024: ch.6). In this sense, agent-projecting, not agent-suppressing, passives are canonical passives. Agent-suppressing passives, in contrast, are not canonical. As will be clear in following sections, agent-suppressing passives are derived by promoting the internal argument to a position lower than that for canonical passives. In this sense, they are “low passives”.

Notable with low passives is that they are distinguished by unique syntactic and semantic properties that align them closely with anticausative constructions, as noted by Alexiadou et al. (2015) on Greek, by Key (2024) on Turkish, and by Bai (2023, 2024) on Mongolian. Their departure from canonical passives is due to the agent being either demoted to an oblique phrase or suppressed entirely, an issue to address in Section 3.

To sum up this section, we have justified (16). Importantly, agent-suppression in low passives must not be used for claiming that passives generally lack agentive arguments. Canonical passives readily allow agentive arguments, which are KPs in the form of either PP or case-marked DP (Collins 2024).

(16) Agents are suppressed in noncanonical (low) passives but not in canonical passives.

Notable is that in canonical passives, implicit agentive/external arguments are not prototypical agents but rather “reduced/defective” agents. We move on to this issue in Section 3.

3. Agent-splitting and INITIATOR-suppression

Why, then, are agents disallowed in low (noncanonical) passives whereas they are allowed in canonical passives? This section answers this question by characterizing the agent-splitting phenomenon found in causatives and passives.

A prototypical agent is composed of two roles, INITIATOR and DOER (Lundin 2003; Sigurðsson and Wood 2021).⁸ As regards passives, either INITIATOR or INITIATOR+DOER (full agent) can be suppressed, which leads to their canonical-low variation and the *u*-syncretic nature of the low/noncanonical type, as will be clear in what follows.

Cross-linguistic facts pointing to agent-splitting are readily available. As noted by Lundin (2003: 134), Swedish light verb *lät* takes an external argument that is not the performer of the action denoted by the base verb, as in *Kalle lät öppna dörren* ‘Kalle had the door opened’. Wood and Sigurðsson (2021) further developed this idea in accounting for a similar light verb used in Icelandic indirect causatives. In what follows, we examine how agent-splitting works by comparing the phenomena in an understudied language Mongolian with those in the well-studied language Icelandic.

3.1. Mongolian

At least three constructions in Mongolian display the agent-splitting property: the body-part causative, the dative causative, and the unergative causative.⁹ In body-part causatives, the causative verb expresses an action performed by a body-part. Such causative verbs and their non-causative variants are used interchangeably. They differ in that the performer and the

variation.

⁸ INITIATOR is responsible for the agentive, sentient aspects of bringing the event about, and a DOER is responsible for performing the physical actions that bring the event about (Sigurðsson and Wood 2021).

⁹ While systematic syntactic analyses of Mongolian causatives are scarce in the literature, descriptive characterizations of them are available in Poppe (1954: 170–171), Sanzheyev (1973: 85), Nasanbayar (1982: 351–352), Daobu (1983: 45–46, 2007: 4–5), Hou (1992), Washio (1993: 62–65), Cinggeltei (1999: 285–286), Kullmann and Tserenpil (2015: 117–123), Janhunen (2012: 248–250), Hashimoto (2019), and Bai (2025a).

initiator of the action are separate for the causative variant while they are identical for the non-causative variant. For example, for *tolgoi-goo bühüi-lge* ‘make one’s head lower’ (causative), one is interpreted as the initiator of the action performed by her/his head, while for *tolgoi-goo bühüi* ‘lower one’s head’, (non-causative), one is interpreted as both the initiator and the performer of action, where one’s head is a patient or theme.

(17) Baatar tolgoi-Ø-oo bühüi(-lge)-sen.

Baatar-NOM head-ACC-RX bow(-CS)-PST

‘Baatar bended his head.’

(18) Baatar-in tolgoi-ni bühüi(*-lge)-sen.

Baatar-GEN head-NOM-[PSS3] bend(*-CS)-PST

‘Baatar’s head bended.’

In the dative causative (19), the dative element *Ulaan* is not interpreted as a prototypical agent or experiencer but rather simply the performer of the looking action. In contrast, the subject *Baatar* just initiates that action but does not physically perform it. This suffices to indicate that the two roles INITIATOR and DOER are split on the two phrases. Note that the causee (DOER here) is accusative-, not instrumental-, marked. Additionally, no canonical “cause to do” meaning is obtained in such causatives, despite the causative morphology.

(19) Baatar Ulaan-d šine mašin-(ϕ)-aa üz-үүл-sen.

Baatar-NOM Ulaan-DAT new car-ACC-RX see-CS-PST

‘Baatar showed Ulaan his new car.’

‘Lit. Baatar made Ulaan look at his car.’

In contrast, the causee is instrumental-marked in canonical causatives, which produce a rigid causative reading such as “cause to do” and “ask to do”, as in (20). In this case, the causee, *Ulaan* here, controls over its action, indicating that it is both INITIATOR and DOER. That is, agent-splitting does not take place here. Importantly, the causee is additionally “controlled” or “supervised” by the subject *Baatar*. Therefore, the subject is a “secondary” INITIATOR, while the “primary” INITIATOR is bundled with DOER on the causee.

(20) Baatar Ulaan-aar šine mašin-(ϕ)-aa üz-үүл-sen.

Baatar-NOM Ulaan-INS new car-ACC-RX see-CS-PST

‘Baatar asked Ulaan to have a look at his new car.’

The difference between (19), featuring agent-splitting, and (20), without agent-splitting, is evidenced by the fact that intentional and manner adverbs can modify the causee’s action in (20), but not in (19). This can be illustrated by English translations such as “Baatar made Ulaan intentionally have a look at his car” and “*Baatar showed Ulaan his car intentionally”. The adverb cannot be associated with *Ulaan* in the latter.

Mongolian features unergative causatives, which are formed by combining an unergative verb with a causative suffix, as exemplified by (22). In unergative causatives, the action denoted by the subject is interpreted as being out of her/his control. Note that the unergative causative and the corresponding plain unergative (21) are used interchangeably to denote the same action. They differ in whether the subject has control over the action, such as coughing.

The causative form (22) is used when the speaker wants to emphasize that the action is out of control. Note that the intentional adverb *zoriuud* ‘deliberately’ is bad with the causative form but fine with the plain form (21). This means that the causative morphology *-lga* here functions to “remove” the volition from the subject, as an agency-reducing effect.

(21) Baatar (zoriuud) haniya-san.

Baatar-NOM deliberately cough-PST

‘Baatar (intentionally) coughed.’

(22) Baatar (*zoriuud) haniya-lga-san.

Baatar-NOM deliberately cough-CS-PST

‘Baatar (intentionally) coughed.’

- ‘Literally: Baatar made (himself) cough.’
 (23) *Baatar öör-ig-öö haniya-lga-san.
 Baatar-NOM self-ACC-RX cough-CS-PST
 ‘Literally: Baatar made himself cough.’

Importantly, the causative form is not semantically causative despite its causative form, since it does not allow a causee, whether it is implicit or overt (23). That is, there is no causee that can be recovered by the causative morphology. Unergative causatives are thus different from the passive causative such as (24–25).

- (24) Bi nohai-d haz-uul-san.
 I dog-DAT bite-CS-PST
 ‘I got bitten by a dog.’
 ‘I had a dog bite me.’
 (25) Bi nohai-d öör-ig-öö haz-uul-san.
 I dog-DAT self-ACC-RX bite-CS-PST
 ‘I got myself bitten by a dog.’
 ‘I had a dog bite me.’

3.2. Icelandic

Mongolian unergative causatives thus resemble Icelandic indirect causatives. In Icelandic indirect causatives, the causative verb *láta* ‘let’ takes an internal argument as a causer, as in (26), which Wood (2015) views as an anticausative-like construction. Notable is that this construction lacks an overt performer of the action denoted by the *-st* verb, as indicated by the fact that a canonical agentive phrase is not allowed. What is introduced by *láta* ‘let’ is an internal argument. Wood (2015: 271) states that “if *láta* ‘let’ takes an external argument with an agent role, it would seem that the surface subject is also absorbing that role”. This naturally follows from the fact that the position (i.e., Spec of the head spelled out by *láta* ‘let’) is occupied by an internal argument, thereby preventing an external causer from being merged there. On the other hand, the external argument of *blekkja* ‘deceive’ with *-st* is “eliminated”, that is, unprojected, due to the merger of a higher head spelled out by *láta* ‘let’ (Wood 2015: 273). All this allows us to say that *láta* ‘let’ behaves like an agency-reducing/deleting morpheme.

- (26) ??Ég lét blekkjast af Jóni.
 I let deceive-st by John
 ‘Literally: I let myself be deceived by John.’ (Wood 2015: 272)

The non-*-st* causative in Icelandic also points to this conclusion. In (27), *láta* ‘let’ introduces an external causer *hún* ‘she’, which initiates the building action but does not physically perform it. The performer of the action is not present. Importantly, agentive modifiers cannot modify the embedded event while manner adverbs can (28).

- (27) Hún lét byggja húsið.
 she-NOM let build the house-ACC
 ‘She made (someone) build the house.’ (Wood 2015: 268)
 (28) Hún lét byggja húsið fljótt/*af kappi.
 she-NOM let build the house-ACC quickly/*enthusiastically
 ‘She made (someone) build the house quickly/*enthusiastically.’ (Wood 2015: 268)

This means that the physical performer of the action lacks agency, while the subject has it, indicating that INITIATOR and DOER are distributed into the subject and the covert causee, respectively.

3.3. The effect of agent-splitting on passives

Note that agents, which have either full or reduced agency, are thus syntactic arguments in passives. This is why they can pass tests for syntactic arguments (cf. Section 2). Interestingly,

LCPs and SCPs diverge when it comes to anaphor binding: as Huang (2025) and others have demonstrated using Chinese data, the agent can only bind an anaphor in LCPs.¹⁰

- (29) Nage xiaohai_i bei Zhangsan_j daihui ziji_{i/j}-de jia qu-le. (LCP)
 that child PS Zhangsan bring back self's home go-PST
 'That child was brought back by Zhangsan to self's home.' (ambiguous) (Huang 2025)
- (30) Nage xiaohai_i bei daihui ziji_{i/*j}-de jia qu-le. (SCP)
 that child PS bring back self's home go-PST
 'That child was brought back to self's home.' (unambiguous) (Huang 2025)

This means that agents as syntactic arguments must be different between LCPs and SCPs. Importantly, as far as the following data is concerned, whenever binding obtains (for testing INITIATOR), a secondary predicate or PRO-controlling (for testing DOER) can be tolerated, as in (31), but not vice versa, as in (32).

- (31) a. Breakfast is usually eaten by the campers_i for themselves_i.
 b. Breakfast is usually eaten nude by the campers_i for themselves_i.
 c. Breakfast is usually eaten nude by the campers_i PRO_i to impress their_i wives.
- (32) a. Breakfast is usually eaten nude.
 b. *Breakfast is usually eaten nude for themselves.
 c. *Breakfast is usually eaten nude PRO_i to impress their_i wives.

This allows us to say that overt agents in LCPs are “fuller” than implicit agents in SCPs. It is thus the case that what overt agents have but implicit agents lack enables the former to bind an anaphor but blocks the latter to do so.

From this it follows that DOER alone cannot be overt in passives. When it is overt, it must be accompanied by INITIATOR, where the passive is LCP. Note that LCPs are characterized by involving overt INITIATOR in addition to DOER. This means that DOER alone, with reduced agency, is an implicit argument and that there does not exist “overt DOER” as a (defective) agent, at least in canonical passives. There does not seem to be evidence for the existence of DOER that occurs alone, with INITIATOR remaining implicit, in canonical passives. Instead, we have evidence that whenever DOER is entailed, INITIATOR is also entailed (31).

3.4. Summary

To sum up, agents are decomposed into INITIATOR and DOER, which may or may not be suppressed in passives. In low passives, both are suppressed; in SCPs, INITIATOR is suppressed but DOER is not; and in LCPs, neither is suppressed. In a nutshell, we have justified (33), which differentiates this section from the literature.

(33) What is suppressed in (short) canonical passives is INITIATOR rather than agents.

The empirical evidence discussed in Sections 3.1 and 3.2 demonstrates that agent-splitting is a syntactic reality, not just a semantic concept. Moving forward, I will show how suppressing the INITIATOR, one of the two split roles, serves to distinguish the Short Causative Passive (SCP) from the Long Causative Passive (LCP).

An agent possessing both INITIATOR and DOER roles is considered prototypical, whereas an agent with a suppressed INITIATOR is viewed as defective or reduced (Lundin 2003). That is, DOER alone is a reduced “agent”. I proceed to show that implicit agents in SCPs are reduced agents (DOER). In other words, what is suppressed in SCP is not a prototypical agent but rather INITIATOR. In LCP, in contrast, neither the agent nor INITIATOR is suppressed. This said, the long-short distinction of passives is attributed to whether INITIATOR is suppressed. In what follows, we discuss the syntactic framework that explains all these

¹⁰ This is also true of languages such as Dutch and Norwegian (Schäfer 2012) and Romance languages (Alexiadou et al. 2015: 129).

properties.

4. The theoretical framework: split VoiceP

According to Key (2024), *u*-syncretism is associated with non-argument-introducing Voice (Voice[−D] here), which is either what he calls active Voice or what he calls nonactive Voice. However, a crucial problem with the Voice[−D] approach is that when a functional head, Voice here, is merged with VP, it has to look ahead at whether a dedicated higher Voice (Pass in Bruening 2013) will be merged above it. If Voice can “see” a prospective higher Voice, then it does not introduce an external argument but rather introduces an external argument role or a variable, and if it cannot “see” a higher Voice, then it introduces an external argument rather than a variable or a role. The essence of the problem with this approach is that it postulates *ad hoc* differential functional heads such as nonactive Voice and active Voice, and a role/variable-introducing D feature designated for capturing the transitive base of passives (Schäfer 2008; Bruening 2013; Alexiadou 2014; Alexiadou et al. 2015; etc.). This deviates from Kratzer’s (1996) original intention of postulating Voice as an argument-introducing, rather than role-introducing, head. Thus, for Key (2024), an overt transitive marker is syntactically vacuous in Turkish canonical passives since it is not associated with a syntactic argument, while it is not vacuous in unembedded transitives. This mismatch of a transitive structure is conceptually undesirable.

In what follows, I show that there is no active-nonactive variation of Voice as a syntactic head and that the syncretic voice morphology in Turkish and other languages is the exponent of an argument-introducing Voice, notated as Voice[+D]. I demonstrate that Voice[+D], being an argument-introducer, may introduce either an external argument via EA or an internal argument via IA, which is allowed by Free Merge (Chomsky 2013, 2015).

4.1. Basic assumptions

Before providing evidence for this, let us first describe the Voice[+D] configuration in (9) in more detail. Henceforth, Voice[+D] is abbreviated as Voice, just for purposes of simplicity; Voice[+D] is used only where necessary. The main takeaway of the Split VoiceP approach is that voice constructions are built by introducing (a) predicate-internal subject(s), notated as sbj1, sbj2, sbj3, etc., through Voice, where any DP from the lexicon/numeration or a constructed syntactic object can be a sbj under Free Merge; a sbj introduced by the highest Voice is promoted to Spec of TP, becoming the surface subject, notated as SBJ (34).¹¹

(34) Split VoiceP: [TP SBJ ... [VoiceP2 sbj2 [VoiceP1 sbj1 [VP]]] ...]¹²

(35) a. [VoiceP1 DP2_j (=sbj1) [VP DP1_i]] — Transitive

b. [VoiceP2 DP1_i (=sbj2) [VoiceP1 DP2_j (=sbj1) [VP t_i]]] — Passive (canonical passive)

c. [VoiceP1 DP1_i (=sbj1) [VP t_i]] — Intransitive (noncanonical/low passive, anticausative)

Any voice construction starts out as [VoiceP sbj [VP DP]], where some DP is to be introduced as sbj, whereby ensuring the subject-predicate relation required for clause building. As allowed by Free Merge, either a new DP (DP2) as an external argument or the internal argument DP1 can be introduced as sbj (sbj1). That is, either EM or IM applies. When EM applies and DP2 is introduced by Voice1, then a transitive structure is yielded, where transitive marking spells out Voice1 (35a). The structure can extend to involve another sbj (sbj2), where either a new DP (DP3) or DP1 is introduced as sbj2.¹³ When DP1 is introduced via IM, a canonical passive

¹¹ For the detailed justification of the Split VoiceP framework and the characterization of predicate-internal subjects, see Bai (2025c) and Bai and Xia (2026).

¹² For a discussion on the iteration of VoiceP up to VoiceP3, see Bai (2025c). This structural expansion is empirically supported by Japanese causative-of-passives and passive-of-causatives, as well as Mongolian transitive-based double causatives, all of which reinforce the validity of the Split VoiceP framework.

¹³ When DP3 is introduced as sbj2, it will be a casuer, yielding a syntactic causative structure. On the

structure is yielded, where passive morphology spells out Voice2 (35b). Voice1 can also introduce DP1 instead of DP2 as *sbj1*, via IM. When this happens, an intransitive structure, subsuming the low/noncanonical passive and the anticausative, is yielded, where passive morphology spells out Voice1 (35c).¹⁴

4.2. Upper VoiceP (VoiceP2)

We now turn to the evidence supporting the characterization of Voice2. Our first task is to confirm that Voice2 introduces an internal argument as a passive subject, as in (35b). A piece of evidence for this comes from the causative-of-passive construction in Japanese, exemplified by (36), in which the non-thematic subject of the embedded passive *Hanako* does not surface in Spec of TP but rather in Spec of a head higher than the head that introduces the agent *Taroo*. *Hanako*, the causee here, must be an argument rather than an adjunct since an adjunct does not take accusative case. *Taroo* is also an argument since the agent can antecede an anaphor, as we have seen in Section 3.

- (36) Ziroo-ga Hanako-o/ni Taroo-ni sikar-are-sase-ta.
 Ziroo-NOM Hanako-ACC/DAT Taroo-DAT scold-PS-CS-PST
 ‘Ziroo made Hanako be scolded by Taroo.’ (Tsujimura 1996: 259)

In addition to Japanese, English provides evidence for subjects of canonical passives occurring in Spec of a head lower than T but higher than Voice1 (roughly corresponding to *v* in Chomsky 1995). The subject of the passive phrase in English transitive expletives (37) and the quantifier *all* in passives (38) does not occupy Spec of TP, indicating that there is an intermediate position for the passive subject. That intermediate position is identified as Spec of VoiceP2.

- (37) There were three people_i arrested *t_i* at the airport. (McCloskey 1997: 215)
 (38) They were all arrested. (Fleisher 2005: 5)

Now we have a look at evidence that Voice1 also introduces an internal argument, as is the case with Voice2. As exemplified by (39), which is an intransitive/anticausative-based causative, the internal argument is promoted to an argument position, thereby being able to bind the anaphor. It is evident that that position is outside VP but inside the causative projection.

- (39) [[Taroo_i-ga [Hanako_j-o [*t_j* zibun_{i/j}-no kuruma-kara ori]] -sase] -ta].
 Taro-NOM Hanako-ACC self-GEN car-from get off-CS-PST
 ‘Taro caused Hanako to get out of his/*her car.’ (Pylkkänen 2008: 73)

The causative here is a syntactic causative, as opposed to a lexical causative, and therefore the causative projection dominates VoiceP1, which is where a lexical causative, akin to the plain transitive, is formed. Accordingly, the causative projection is VoiceP2 above VoiceP1. It then follows that the accusative causee *Hanako*, the subject of the phrase embedded by VoiceP2, occupies Spec of VoiceP1, where an external argument also occurs in transitives.

- (40) [TP [VoiceP2 Taroo_i [VoiceP1 Hanako_j-o [VP *t_j* from self_{i/j}’s car get off] Ø] -sase] -ta].

Note that the accusative causee is not in-situ. This is evidenced by the fact that the productive causative form *ori-sase* ‘cause to come down’ alternates with the lexical causative form *or-os* ‘take down’, where only for the latter does an accusative phrase surface as an in-situ object, failing to bind an anaphor.

Now it is clear that a Voice head, Voice1 or Voice2, always introduces an argument via either EM or IM. As such, there is no Voice[−D] and therefore *u*-syncretism turns out to be associated with Voice[+D], contrary to Key (2024) and others.

other hand, in principle, the external argument DP2 can also be introduced as *sbj2* under Free Merge. However, the promotion of DP2 from Spec of Voice1 to that of Voice2 does not change the syntactic information such as word order, which causes the failure of structure extension. This is why the structure with the promotion of DP2 is uninstatiated in languages. See Bai (2025c) and Bai and Xia (2026) for more details.

¹⁴ When DP1 is coreferential with DP2, a reflexive is yielded.

4.3. Lower VoiceP (VoiceP1)

What follows elaborates on VoiceP1. Voice1 may be further split into two heads, notated as Voice1a and Voice1b,¹⁵ taking care of INITIATOR and DOER, respectively, in the case of deriving transitives/causatives, as in (41a).

- (41) a. [VoiceP1(a+b) INITIATOR+DOER [VP]] (not split → transitive/lexical causative)
 b. [VoiceP1a INITIATOR [VoiceP1b DOER [VP]]] (split → causative)

The split structure (41b) is evidenced by Icelandic indirect causatives (Section 3; Wood 2015) and three Mongolian constructions (Section 3), including the body-part causative, the dative causative, and the unergative causative. Recall that, for example, in indirect causatives, the subject initiates the action and the overt causee performs it. Such causatives naturally fall in the split VoiceP structure under discussion. Voice1a (“upper Voice” in Wood and Sigurðsson’s 2021) and Voice1b (“lower Voice” in Wood and Sigurðsson’s 2021) take care of INITIATOR (the subject) and DOER (the understood causee), respectively, as shown below.

- (42) [VoiceP1a Hún lét [VoiceP1b ____ [VP byggja húsið]]]
 she-NOM let build the house-ACC

I suggest that *lét* ‘let’ is the spell-out of Voice rather than a vacuous head *v*, and *byggja* ‘build’ spells out Voice1b and V in a form of spanning (contrary to Wood 2015: 268). This is because causative morphology is supposed to spell out a head that introduces an associated causer (i.e., the subject *hún* ‘she’ here) unless it is part of the lexical root verb, complying with the Mirror Principle.

At least one of INITIATOR or DOER must be syntactically present in the case of deriving causatives; they cannot both be absent while maintaining the required structure extension. That is, Voice1a or Voice1b or both must introduce (an) argument(s) via either EM or IM, as represented in (43) through (45). Icelandic indirect causatives (42) and Mongolian unergative causatives (22) instantiate (43), in which INITIATOR is projected while DOER is not. They differ in that indirect causatives are dyadic, possessing INITIATOR and a patient, while unergative causatives are monadic, only possessing INITIATOR.¹⁶

- (43) [VoiceP1a INITIATOR [VoiceP1b ____ [VP]]]
 (Icelandic indirect/Mongolian unergative causative)

Conversely, DOER is located within VoiceP1, whereas INITIATOR is projected outside it, i.e., within VoiceP2. Mongolian dative causatives such as (19) have this structure, where the dative phrase is DOER while the subject is base-generated as INITIATOR in Spec of VoiceP2, left out here.

- (44) [VoiceP1a ____ [VoiceP1b DOER [VP]]] (Mongolian dative causative)

Mongolian body-part causatives (17) have the structure (45), in which both INITIATOR and DOER are present within VoiceP1.

- (45) [VoiceP1a INITIATOR [VoiceP1b DOER [VP]]] (Mongolian body-part causative)

Given that Voice is an underspecified functional head, any DPs introduced by Voice1a and Voice1b are not predetermined as INITIATOR and DOER. These roles are contextually

¹⁵ Voice1a and Voice1b here correspond to Nie (2020) and Wood and Sigurðsson’s (2021) upper Voice and lower Voice, respectively. Berro et al. (2025) hold that in indirect causatives in Basque, the causee (DP2 here), which they view as an Affectee of the action, is introduced by Voice1b (their low Voice), which, they state (2025: 1296), resembles Pykkänen’s (2008) Applicative head. Chen (2024: 9) holds that Affectees (roughly identical to causees) in causatives are introduced by Applicative.

¹⁶ As noted in Section 3.1, unergative causatives express uncontrolled actions such coughing and yawning, while corresponding plain unergatives (those without causative morphology) do not. In this regard, unergative causatives resemble Icelandic indirect causatives (Wood 2015: 272), both reducing the agency to some extent. Wood (2015: 272) states that Icelandic indirect causatives are somewhere in between an anticausative and a passive.

determined instead. That is, VP containing an internal argument DP (DP1) extends to involve new nominals DP2 and DP3 in that order, then DP2 is DOER and DP3 is INITIATOR. Alternatively, when these two roles are bundled on a single nominal DP2, then DP2 is a prototypical agent. If the structure further extends to involve another nominal DP3, then it is INITIATOR, which is an independent causer.

These properties are typical of the causatives. Below, we turn to how the above elaboration sheds light on passive derivation. Due to the underspecification nature of Voice and Free Merge, the internal argument DP1 can also be reintroduced (i.e., promoted via IM). If DP1 is promoted to Spec of VoiceP1a skipping DP2 in Spec of VoiceP1b, then DP1 is not INITIATOR or a causer, and therefore DP2 will not be contextually identified as DOER. Lacking DOER status, DP2 fails to qualify even as a reduced agent; it is strictly an oblique argument, representing an “agent-demoted-to-oblique” effect. The resulting structure is then a low passive (46), which resembles a dyadic anticausative. This is readily exemplified by (14).¹⁷

(46) [_{VoiceP1a} DP1_i [_{VoiceP1b} DP2 (oblique) [_{VP} *t_i*]]] (low passive: dyadic anticausative)

DP1 can also be promoted to Spec of the non-split VoiceP1, yielding a monadic anticausative (47), as exemplified by (51b) and (52b).

(47) [_{VoiceP1} DP1_i [_{XP} *t_i*]]] (monadic anticausative)

Note that this latter case is not passivization in a strict sense because the promotion of the internal argument DP1 does not skip a higher DP.

If DP1 is promoted to Spec of VoiceP2 skipping DP2 in Spec of the non-split VoiceP1, then the resulting structure is a long canonical passive (48).

(48) [_{VoiceP2} DP1_i [_{VoiceP1} DP2 (INITIATOR+DOER) [_{VP} *V t_i*]]] (long canonical passive)

Alternatively, DP1 is promoted to Spec of VoiceP2 skipping the reduced agent DP2 (DOER) in Spec of VoiceP1b, the resulting structure being a short canonical passive (49).

(49) [_{VoiceP2} DP1_i [_{VoiceP1} DP2 (DOER_{implicit}) [_{VP} *t_i*]]] (short canonical passive)

Note that in SCPs, DP2 is present in the syntax but absent from PF, while in LCPs, DP2 is present in both the syntax and PF, as discussed in Section 2.

4.4. Deriving *u*-syncretism

As regards spell-out forms of Voice, only when the promotion of an internal argument DP1 does not skip DP2 is it possible for Voice to have different morpho-phonological forms than passive morphology. This is truly the case as evidenced by Turkish *ol*-marked anticausatives and Mongolian *r*-marked anticausatives, as discussed in detail in Section 5. *Ol*- and *r*- are not passive morphology but rather dedicated verbalizers used to create intransitive/anticausative verbs by attaching to a non-verb root. Passive morphology is preferably or only available where internal argument promotion skip some DP within some VoiceP, causing a word change from DP2→DP1 to DP1→DP2. This word order change may occur across VoiceP1 and VP (in the case of low passives), or across VoiceP2, VoiceP1, and VP (in the case of canonical passives). In either case, the affixation of passive morphemes signals the promotion of internal arguments, as a Mirror Principle effect. Importantly, since both low passivization and anticausative formation occur within the low Voice layer, i.e., VoiceP1, passive morphology may function like anticausativizing morphology. Moreover, when DP2 is positioned in Spec of VoiceP1b during low passivization (within VoiceP1), its failure to function even as a reduced agent forces the structure to be interpreted as unaccusative rather than transitive. This, I demonstrate, is the very source of *u*-syncretism. Accordingly, *u*-syncretism is not simply a manifestation of a

¹⁷ The reduced-agent status of DP2 is evident in both noncanonical passives and causatives. Thus, causative and passive morphemes could be regarded as deagentivizing morphemes, which function to reduce/demote agency. This is not a result of the theoretical postulation of Voice as a specific syntactic head; rather, it reflects the decompositional nature of agents, which is indeed a linguistic reality.

uniform syntactic head with different meanings, contrary to Embick (2004). Neither does it arise from nonactive Voice head, contrary to Key (2024); it arises from internal argument promotion, as formulated in (38).¹⁸

5. Passive versus Anticausative

This section shows how the proposed analysis can explain the difference between passives and anticausatives in their derivation using Turkish and Mongolian data.

(50) Passive vs. anticausative in Turkish and Mongolian

	Passive morpheme		Anticausative morpheme
Turkish	<i>-Il</i>		<i>ol-</i>
Mongolian	<i>-gd</i>		<i>-r</i>
Stem type	marked transitive	unmarked transitive	non-verb
Meaning	rigid passive only	rigid/non-rigid passive (anticausative)	anticausative
Voice level	high	low	low

As summarized in (50), both Turkish and Mongolian employ two strategies in expressing an anticausative meaning (Key 2024). In Turkish, the passive suffix *-Il* (and its allomorphs) and the intransitive light verb *ol-* are employed. *-Il* expresses an anticausative meaning where it is affixed to a non-transitive-marked verb stem (51a). It expresses a rigidly interpreted passive meaning where it is affixed to a transitive stem marked by a causative suffix or the active light verb *eD-* (51b). Since a predicate with passive morphology expressing an anticausative meaning instantiates the low passive, *-Il* is a low passive marker with a null-transitive stem (51a), while it is a canonical passive marker with an overtly marked transitive stem (51b). The intransitive light verb *ol-* is used to form an unaccusative verb from a non-verbal base (51c); it is not a passive marker.

- (51) a. *aç-ıl* ‘open (intr)’ (passive of unmarked transitive (low passive/anticausative))
 b. *öl-dür-ül* ‘be killed’ (passive of marked transitive/causative (canonical passive))
 c. *yok ol-* ‘disappear’ (intransitive (non-passive))

Similarly, Mongolian employs both a passive suffix (*-gd*) and a verbalizing (intransitivizing) one (*-r*) for anticausatives (Bai 2025a). When used as an anticausative (low passive) marker, *-gd* can only be merged with a transitive stem without an overt marker (52a). When occurring with the causative suffix *-AA*,¹⁹ *-gd* can only express a canonical/rigid passive meaning (52b). As in (52c), the inchoative suffix *-r* functions to verbalize (intransitivize) a non-verbal base.

- (52) a. *nem-gd* ‘increase (intr)’ (passive of unmarked transitive (low passive/anticausative))
 b. *šat-aa-gd* ‘be burned’ (passive of marked transitive/causative (canonical passive))
 c. *niča-r* ‘smash (intr)’ (intransitive (non-passive))

¹⁸ The correlation between Split VoiceP and low/noncanonical passives suggests that agent-splitting and the demotion of roles, such as from agent to recipient or beneficiary, result from structural density and the downward pressure exerted by the higher VoiceP layer. Specifically, when consecutive Voice layers are present, the lower layer is compressed against the higher one; consequently, the former undergoes truncation, or the argument in its specifier experiences role dissociation or mutation. However, this structural compression is not obligatory. Specifically, in canonical passives and causatives, the lower Voice layer is compressed against a higher one, thereby avoiding agent-splitting or role demotion.

Given the nature of Voice as an underspecified argument-introducer, voice constructions appear to be governed by formal rather than thematic relations. These relations involve predicate-internal subjects, which are not restricted to transitives but are available across various voice constructions, including passives and across both matrix and embedded clauses, as Bai and Xia (2026) argue.

¹⁹ Traditional studies on Mongolian syntax including grammar books have not taken *-r* and *-l* as an alternating equipollent pair of inchoative and causative suffixes. Bai (2025a), however, includes *-l* in the list of Mongolian causative suffixes, characterizing it as a realization of a terminal node, which is a bundle of Voice and the verbalizing light verb *v*.

Key (2024: 358) analyzes both types of *II*- and *ol*-marked anticausatives in Turkish as associated with nonactive head Voice_{nact}. According to him, *II*-marked anticausatives (noncanonical/low passives) are derived by merging Voice_{nact} with vP (v being a verbalizer), and *ol*-marked ones (pure anticausatives) are derived by bundling nonactive head Voice_{nact} with v into one. The internal argument would be promoted to the subject position in a single step.

(53) a. [TP DP1_i [VoiceP-nact *II* / -*gd* [vP [vP t_i]]]] (low passive/anticausative)

b. [TP DP1_i [VoiceP-nact(+v) *ol*- / -*r* [XP t_i]]] (pure anticausative)

Thus, for Key (2024), nonactive Voice (Voice[-D]) is the source of *u*-syncretism. The same analysis would be carried over to Mongolian on this view.

In contrast, under the proposed Voice[+D] analysis, passive-marked anticausatives (*II*- and *gd*-marked anticausatives) are derived by promoting the internal argument DP1 to Spec of VoiceP1a, as in (54), and pure anticausatives (*ol*- and *r*-marked anticausatives) are derived by promoting DP1 to Spec of VoiceP1b (or the non-split VoiceP1), as in (55).

(54) [VoiceP1a DP1_i [VoiceP1b DP2 (oblique) *II* / -*gd* [vP t_i]]] (low passive/anticausative: dyadic)

(55) [VoiceP1(+v) DP1_i *ol*- / -*r* [XP t_i]]] (pure anticausative: monadic)

In (54), *II* and *gd* spell out Voice1a. Voice1b is null-marked; it cannot be spelled out by transitive marking although it introduces DP2 since DP2 is not an agent;²⁰ it is not even DOER (reduced agent). Rather, it is a non-agentive argument, expressing natural force here; it could be characterized as a “cause” (not “causer”) argument. Thus, DP2 is more like an adjunct than an argument, and can be absent at PF, as in (56) and (57).²¹

(56) Pankart (sert rüzgar-dan) yırt-ıl-dı.

banner strong wind-ABL tear-PS-PST

‘The banner tore (from the strong wind)’ (Key 2024 : 348)

(57) Üüd (salhin-d) nee-gd-sen.

door wind-DAT open-PS-PST

‘The door opened from the wind.’

In (55), *ol*- and *r*- spell out Voice1, which is in fact a bundle of Voice1 and v, the verbalizer. The same is true of the corresponding causative suffixes *eD*- and *-l*, where they spell out the bundle of Voice1 and v. *ol*- and *-r* differ from *eD*- and *-l* in that the former are associated with internal argument promotion while the latter with external argument projection. A comparison of the intransitive and transitive light verbs is exemplified in (58) and (59).

(58) Anticausative/causative suffixes and in Turkish (Key 2024: 375)

Noun/Adjective	Intransitive (anticausative)	Transitive (causative)
<i>yok</i> ‘nonexistent’	<i>yok ol-</i> ‘disappear’	<i>yok eD-</i> ‘destroy’
<i>hasta</i> ‘sick’	<i>hasta ol-</i> ‘get sick’	<i>hasta eD-</i> ‘make sick’

(59) Anticausative/causative suffixes and in Mongolian (Shiotani 2007: 186–187)

Adverb	Intransitive (anticausative)	Transitive (causative)
<i>niča</i> (status of being smashed)	<i>niča-r</i> ‘smash (intr)’	<i>niča-l</i> ‘smash (tr)’
<i>delbe</i> (status of being blasted)	<i>delbe-r</i> ‘blow up (intr)’	<i>delbe-l</i> ‘blow up (tr)’

In a nutshell, internal argument promotion to the low Voice layer, i.e., VoiceP1, makes passives behave like anticausatives, thereby leading to their *u*-syncretic nature.

As regards passive semantics, I argue that it is not the meaning of Voice, contrary to Alexiadou and Doron (2011), Bruening (2013), Alexiadou et al. (2015), etc. Voice is simply an argument-introducer (introducer of predicate-internal subjects, strictly speaking (cf. Bai

²⁰ Voice1b here is not spelled out by transitive marking for two reasons. First, transitive marking is a signature of agentivity but DP2 is not an agent. Second, split heads, Voice1a and Voice1b here, cannot be both spelled out by respective overt morphemes. That is, where Voice1a is spelled out, Voice1b remains null.

²¹ In Pytkänen’s (2008) term, DP2 would be an applied argument, introduced by what she calls Low Applicative head. Kallulli and Roberts (2024) treat all non-core arguments and agents (DP2 here) alike, arguing that they are merged in the same position, namely, Spec of vP, which corresponds to VoiceP1(b) here.

2025c)). Rather, passive semantics is the meaning interpreted for a configuration in which an internal argument is promoted, whether the agent is suppressed or not; it is assigned to the configuration at LF, as is the case with morphological causatives, where causative semantics is configurationally produced (Nie 2020). In other words, passive semantics is not located in one spot but emerges from the configuration of the whole tree containing a promoted internal argument skipping an external argument or a position that normally introduces a nominal as an external argument. Due to internal argument promotion to Spec of VoiceP1 (VoiceP1a or VoiceP1b) in low passives, a non-rigid passive reading arises, where agents are suppressed to oblique phrases as non-core arguments. This is evident cross-linguistically, for example, in the languages discussed in this paper including Turkish, Mongolian, and Icelandic.

6. Consequences and implications

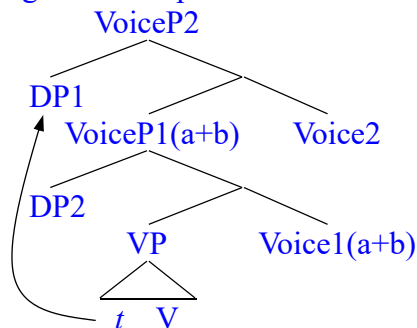
In conclusion, this paper has argued that passive variation and *u*-syncretism must be analyzed through Voice[+D] (the argument-introducing head) rather than Voice[−D] (non-argument-introducing Voice) and that the phenomena can only be correctly explained by decomposing the agent into two sub-roles such as INITIATOR and DOER.

Specifically, the distinction between canonical and noncanonical passives arises from the promotion of an internal argument to different structural heights. In canonical passives, the internal argument targets a Voice layer (Voice2) higher than the one (Voice1) that normally takes care of agents (60a, b). In contrast, noncanonical passives are derived over the low Voice layer, which is split between two layers, where the internal argument is promoted to the higher one (60c). (60a) and (60c) differ in that the latter features agent-splitting. In other words, the “by-phrase” in long canonical passives are prototypical agents while agents are split and its INITIATOR role is suppressed in noncanonical passives. Internal argument promotion targets a position lower in the latter than in the former, instantiating “low passive”. (60a) and (60b) differ in that the overt agent of the former is prototypical while the implicit agent of the latter is “reduced”. Additionally, the former is overt while the latter is implicit. (60d) is not a passive if we take “passivization” as internal argument promotion over a higher argument in a Voice layer, but rather a pure anticausative. This leads to the fact that Voice can be spelled out by dedicated anticausative morphology different than passive morphology. If passive morphology spells out Voice, the resulting structure is in fact a monadic anticausative or unaccusative.

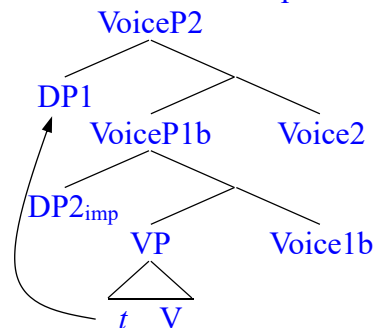
Therefore, passive morphology is shared more possibly by (60a), (60b), and (60c), while true *u*-syncretism arises with the noncanonical passive (60c), where an anticausative meaning is available in addition to a passive meaning within or across languages.²²

(60) Passives (and anticausatives)

a. Long canonical passive

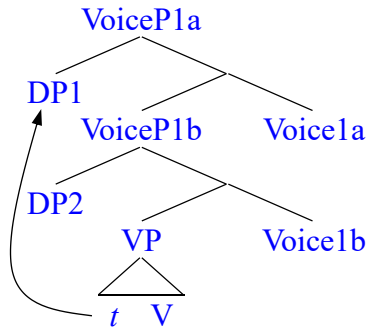


b. Short canonical passive

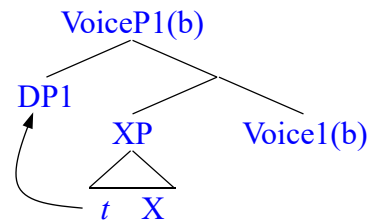


²² Reflexive interpretations are expressed using the same morphology that also marks passives and anticausatives, where an internal argument is referentially linked to an external argument.

c. Noncanonical/Low passive (anticausative)



d. Pure anticausative (non-passive)



Notably, transitive marking is null due to the absence of external arguments; DP2 is not even a reduced agent but rather a non-core argument (or an adjunct-like phrase), as noted in Section 4, leading to the fact that VoiceP1b is not a transitive structure. In contrast, the selecting for VP Voice (i.e., Voice1(a+b) or Voice1b) in long and short canonical passives in (60a) and (60b) may have overt transitive marking and therefore they do not exhibit true *u*-syncretism, despite the same passive morphology spelling out Voice2. This naturally explains why *u*-syncretism arises where transitive marking is null, as empirically observed by Key (2024). It, however, cannot be attributed to so-called nonactive Voice, contrary to Key's (2024) theoretical claim. UG does not provide such a head in the inventory of functional heads.

All this leads to the conclusion that rather than a nonactive Voice head, it is the promotion of an internal argument to the Voice layer that unites syncretic voice constructions and explains the syncretic nature of passive morphology. *U*-syncretism is therefore not merely a case of morphological ambiguity; rather, it manifests a Voice-domain architecture centered on internal argument promotion, which blocks external argument projection.

A significant consequence is that Voice is a syntactic head specified neither for voice alternations (active vs. nonactive) nor for transitivity (transitive/causative vs. passive). This underspecification extends to argument selection, where Free Merge allows Voice to introduce either external or internal arguments. Rather than being encoded in the head, Voice semantics is assigned at LF to a VoiceP configuration. Voice is devoid of [active/nonactive] features, which are not syntactic primitives; instead, the system relies on the Minimalist efficiency of Free Merge acting upon a single Voice category, rather than a collection of alternating Voice heads.

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